UX RESEARCH CASE STUDY

Asking the Right Population

A mobile discovery survey built around a non-customer comparison group, so that low usage of our app could be told apart from low demand in the market



Keap customers 230

Thryv customers 146

ICP non-customers 143

519 respondents · 3 groups · Qualtrics survey · Sole researcher · February 2026

The study at a glance

The mobile app team wanted to know what to build. The prior question, which nobody had asked out loud, was whether small businesses run on mobile at all.

519

respondents across three independently recruited groups

90%

of ICP non-customer owners run their business from a mobile app

35%

of Keap customers did not know our mobile app existed, and 36% of Thryv customers

17

tool categories used by 30% or more of non-customers, against 5 for Keap and 3 for Thryv

What the study settled

The market-fit debate closed, because the comparison group showed demand our own customers could not. Awareness became a workstream rather than a footnote. And the team stopped planning one app for two populations that wanted very different things.

01

The problem

Low usage is a number with two readings, and the evidence we had could not separate them

One number, two readings

Both Thryv and Keap had a mobile app. Neither was getting much use, and both were showing their age. The team wanted to invest. Leadership wanted to know whether investing was the right call at all.

Reading one: the category

Small business owners do not run their businesses from a phone. Low usage is a verdict on mobile, and the correct decision is to stop investing.

Reading two: the product

Small business owners do run their businesses from a phone, just not from ours. Low usage is a verdict on us, and the correct decision is to find out what is blocking them.

Every piece of evidence we held came from inside our own products. A population that is already not using your app cannot tell you whether the category has value, because every answer it gives is downstream of your product.

02

How I designed it

Three groups rather than one, kept separate rather than pooled

Three groups, one of which was the point

Keap customers

N = 230

51% established, 43% growing, 6% new small businesses.

The group with the most mobile appetite and the most specific complaints.

Thryv customers

N = 146

79% established and larger, 21% growing.

A noticeably heavier skew than Keap, which shapes how its answers read.

ICP non-customers

N = 143

70% owners, 30% employees. 67% growing businesses.

Drawn from our ideal customer profile, and had never used either product.

Why the third group earned its budget

Whatever those 143 people did with their phones was what the market does, not what our product had trained people to do. It gave me a clean behavioral baseline to read the customer numbers against. Keeping Keap and Thryv apart rather than pooling them was the second decision, and it turned out to matter nearly as much.

What the survey asked

Fielded in Qualtrics. Four areas, sequenced so that behavior was captured before preference.

1

Behavior outside our products

Whether they use mobile apps to run the business, how often, on what device, and for which activities. Asked of all three groups.

2

The tool stack

Which of eighteen categories of business software they use on mobile. This is where the breadth difference between groups surfaced.

3

Perceived need and friction

Whether they need mobile business management at all, and whether they have hit problems running the business on the go.

4

The ideal app, and the blockers

What an ideal CRM mobile app would contain, how tasks and qualities rank, and for customers, why they were not using the app we already had.

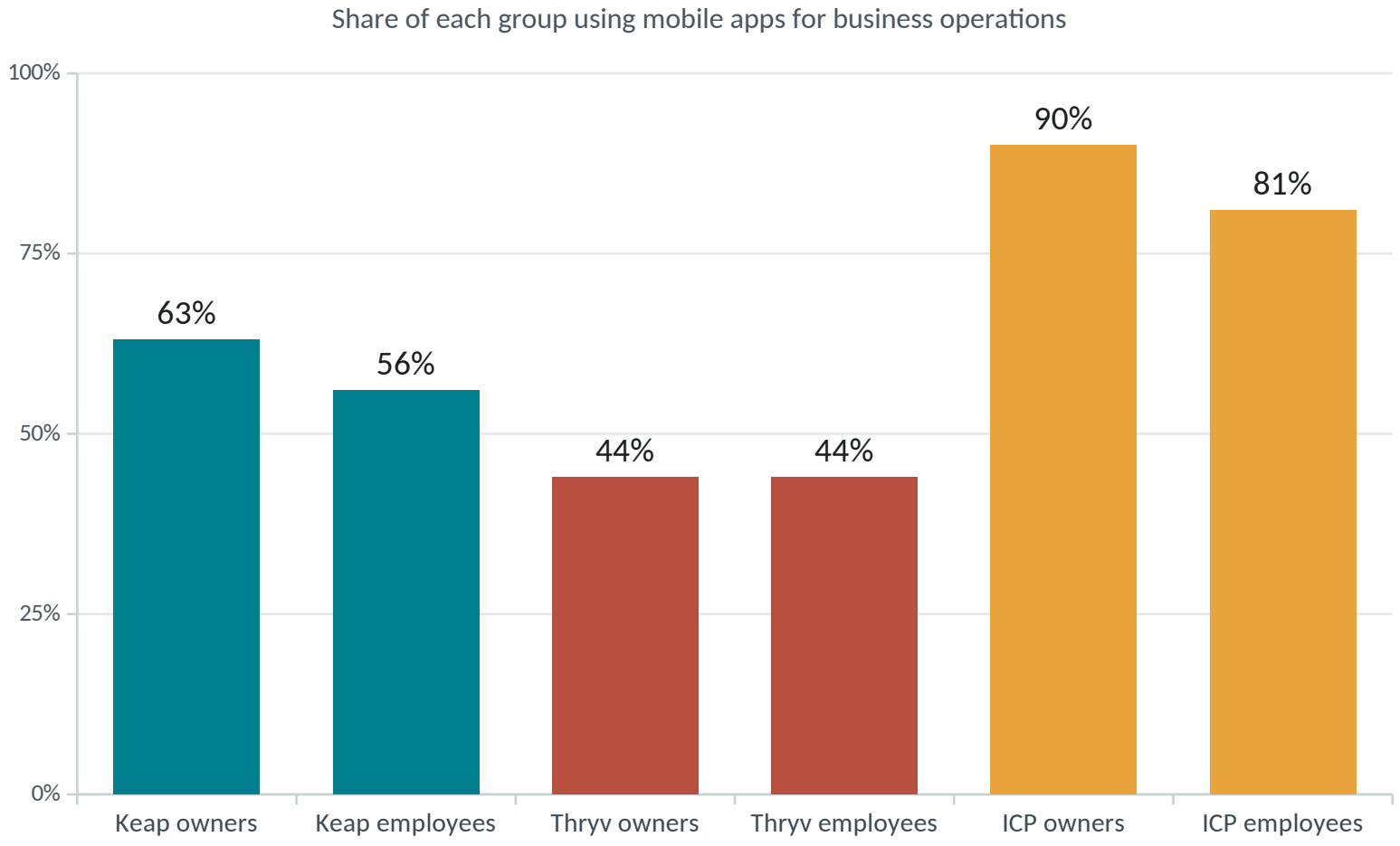
Blocker questions were routed only to people who could meaningfully answer them. Non-customers answered the behavioral and ideal-state sections.

03

What came back

The comparison group did exactly what it was recruited to do, which was to make the customer numbers legible

The comparison that reframed the question



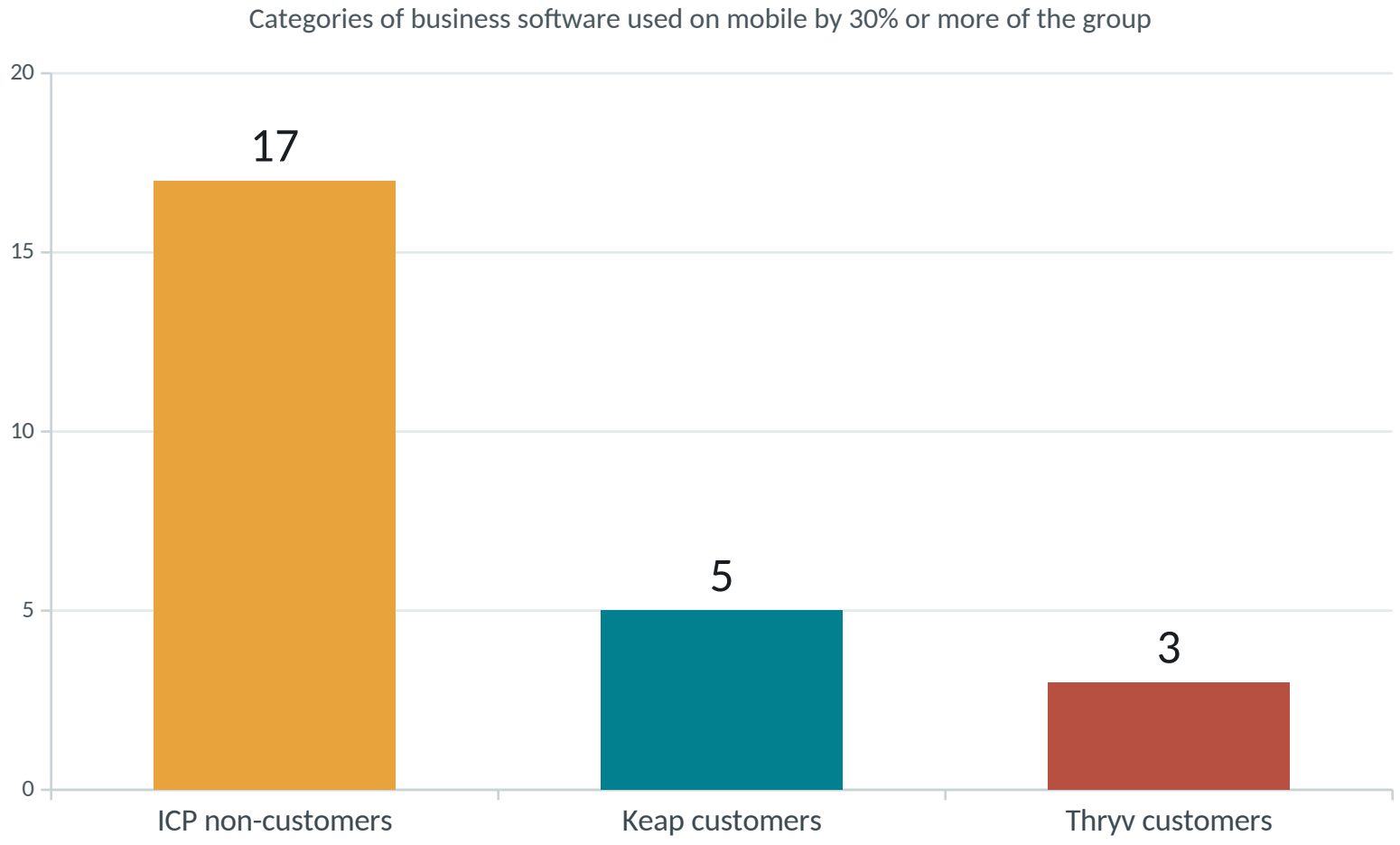
Read on its own, 44% looks like a market that does not want mobile.

Read next to 90%, it looks like something else entirely.

Of the non-customers who use mobile for business, 76% do it daily. Daily use was near identical across all three groups at 73%, 76% and 76%, so the difference is in whether people start, not in how committed they are once they do.

Roughly one third of every group also uses a tablet, which quietly rules out a phone-only design.

The number that made the room go quiet



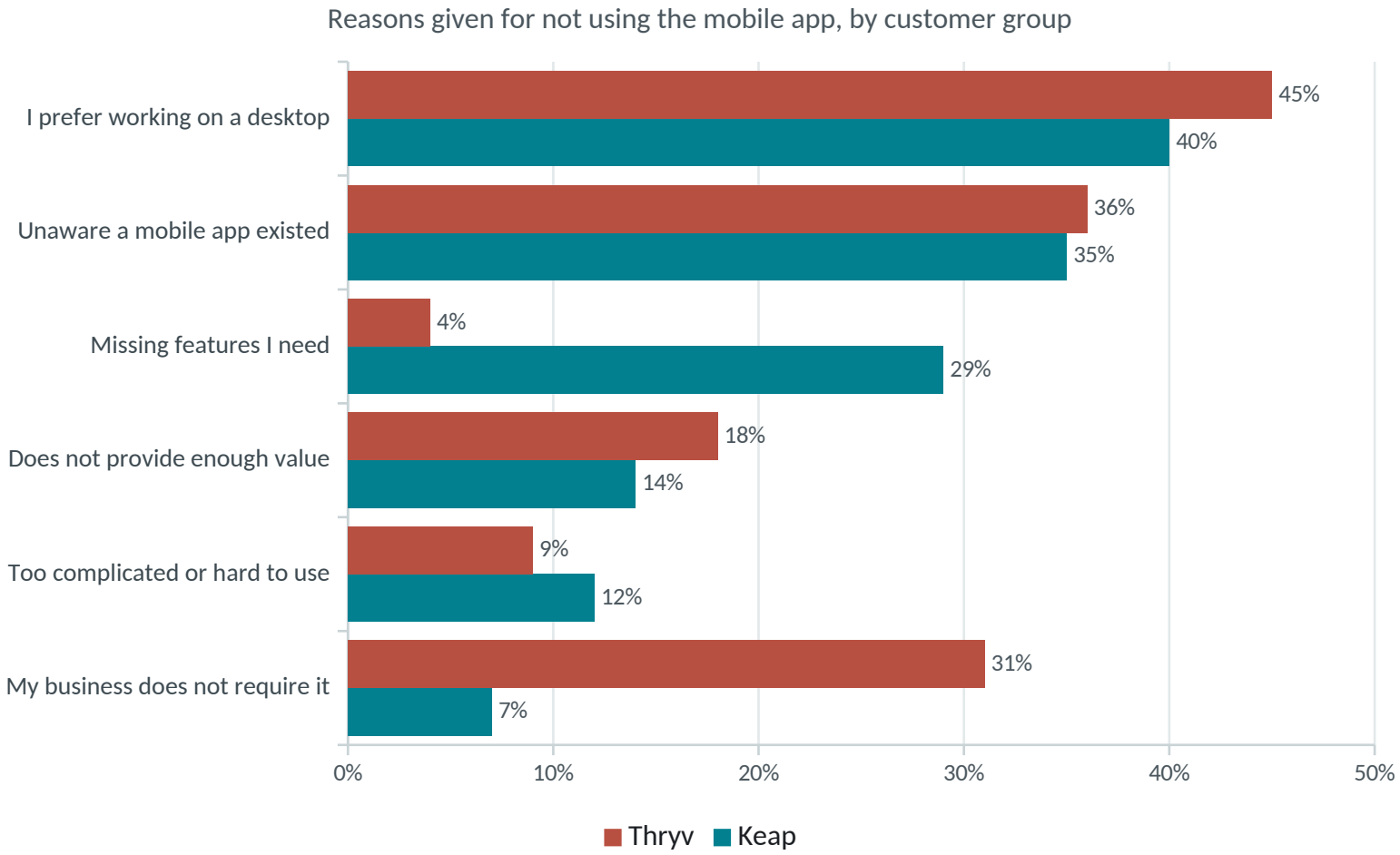
The people outside our products were not doing less on mobile than our customers. They were doing substantially more, across a far wider surface, and paying other vendors for it.

Non-customer tool use sat 20 to 30 percentage points higher than customers across every activity measured.

Top three for non-customers: managing all customer communication in one place, payment processing, and email and text reminders.

Top three for both customer groups: email and text reminders, social media management, and bookings and scheduling.

Why customers were not using the app we had



A third of our own paying customers did not know the app existed.

That is a distribution problem, not a product-market-fit verdict, and no amount of feature work fixes it.

It also contaminates the preference data. An answer to “would you use a mobile version” from someone unaware one exists is an answer about an imagined product.

The missing-features gap is the other story here: 29% for Keap against 4% for Thryv. The two groups were not blocked by the same thing.

Keap and Thryv are not one population

Pooling the two customer groups would have produced an average that described neither of them.

	Keap customers	Thryv customers
Need mobile business management	67%	34%
Would benefit from us on mobile	59%	30%
Want full desktop feature parity	44%	22%
Would not use a mobile version at all	21%	56%
Blocked by missing features	29%	4%
Business does not require mobile apps	7%	31%

Keap has appetite and specific grievances, which makes it where mobile investment pays back soonest. Thryv, skewed toward larger and more established businesses, mostly does not want it. One strategy written to the average of these two would have served neither.

Where all three groups agreed

Rankings, where 1 is most beneficial or most important. The convergence is what the roadmap was eventually built on.

Which business tasks matter most

Task	Keap	Thryv	ICP
Customer messaging and communication	1	1	1
Scheduling and calendar	2	2	4
Tracking leads or customers	3	6	5
Task and project management	4	4	3
Marketing and promotions	5	3	6
Accepting payments and sending invoices	6	5	2

Which app qualities matter most

Attribute	Keap	Thryv	ICP
Ease of use	1	1	1
Range of features	2	4	4
Reliable performance	3	3	3
Integration with desktop and other tools	4	2	2

Messaging first, ease of use first, reliability third, for every group. The disagreement sits entirely in the middle of each list, which is exactly where a roadmap can afford to differ by product.

The finding I argued against

44% of Keap respondents said they wanted a mobile app that replicates the full desktop experience. That number has an obvious reading, and the obvious reading is wrong.

What they said they want

Full parity with desktop. It costs a respondent nothing to say, and it is easier to describe a solution than a need.

Taken literally, it commits the team to a multi-year project whose first shippable increment is years away.

What they said they do

Communication, scheduling, social media and task management, in that order, with payments trailing.

Only one of these two answers is grounded in something the respondent has actually done.

I wrote it up as a demand for confidence, not a demand for scope. People wanted to know the thing they needed would be there, not that everything would be. I flagged the 44% in the roll-up as the single number most likely to be misread.

04

What it changed

And what I would do differently if I ran it again

What it changed

1

The question moved from whether to where

It is difficult to argue the category has no value when 90% of the comparison group lives in it daily, across seventeen tool types.

2

Awareness became a workstream

A third of paying customers not knowing a product exists had been invisible, because nobody had asked the question in a form that let it surface.

3

The team stopped planning one app

Keap first, where appetite and specific grievances make the payback fastest. For Thryv, integration and reliability for the minority who want it.

4

The feature floor came from the convergence

Messaging first, scheduling second, built to be easy and reliable before being broad. Defensible to all three groups at once, which little else in the data was.

The roll-up went to the mobile app team and to product leadership, and fed an integrated mobile strategy spanning both customer bases.

What I would do differently

Limitations I put in the deck

- A survey measures claims, not behavior. Self-reported usage is generous and stated preference predicts adoption poorly.
- The Thryv sample skewed 79% established and larger against Keap's 51%, so part of the gap between them may be composition rather than product.
- Preference answers from the third who did not know the app existed are contaminated. I reported them and flagged it rather than quietly dropping those respondents.
- The groups were recruited to be compared but were not powered to be. Fine for differences this size, not for smaller ones.

What I would change

- Ask about awareness before preference and route accordingly, so preference data comes only from people who know what they are judging.
- Make respondents trade. “Which three would you give up to get it six months sooner” survives contact with a roadmap in a way that “would you like parity” does not.
- Design the group comparison as the primary analysis from the start, with sizes and demographic balance set in recruitment rather than discovered in analysis.
- Pair the survey with store analytics and usage logs, because the places where claimed and real behavior disagree are the most interesting part of a discovery study.
- Run a qualitative follow-up on the 29%. The survey can tell you features are missing. It cannot tell you which.